

Nigeria Telecommunications Market Analysis

Full Project Insights

Study period: January 2023 – May 2026

1. Executive Summary

The analysis reveals a major structural transformation in Nigeria's telecommunications market. Over the study period, the overall subscriber base declined, while Internet data consumption increased dramatically. At the same time, market share shifted strongly toward MTN and Airtel, and subscribers migrated from older 2G and 3G technologies toward 4G and 5G.

The central finding is that subscriber volume alone no longer captures the changing character of the market. The market became smaller in subscriber numbers but substantially more data-intensive.

2. Subscriber Market Trend

Total subscribers declined from approximately **225.88 million** in the starting month to **189.68 million** in May 2026. This represents a reduction of about **36.20 million subscribers**, or approximately **16.0%**.

This contraction indicates that the market experienced a decline in overall active subscriptions during the study period. However, the contraction was not evenly distributed across operators.

3. Operator Market-Share Restructuring

Operator	Starting share	Latest share	Change
MTN	40.65%	51.13%	+10.48 pp
Airtel	26.77%	34.51%	+7.74 pp
Globacom	26.67%	12.37%	–14.30 pp
T2	5.76%	1.87%	–3.89 pp

MTN and Airtel both increased their market shares, while Globacom and T2 experienced substantial declines. The combined share of MTN and Airtel increased from **67.42%** to **85.64%**, a gain of **18.22 percentage points**. This indicates a significant increase in market concentration around the two leading operators.

The subscriber figures reinforce this pattern: MTN increased from about 91.95 million to 96.98 million subscribers, while Airtel increased from about 60.56 million to 65.45 million. Globacom declined from about 60.33 million to 23.47 million, while T2 declined from about 13.03 million to 3.54 million.

4. Internet Data Usage

Internet data usage increased from approximately **517.67 thousand TB** to **1.50 million TB**, representing an increase of roughly **190%**.

This is one of the most significant findings because it occurred while the subscriber base was declining. The result indicates that overall Internet consumption became substantially more intensive over the study period.

5. Average Monthly Data Usage per Subscriber

Average monthly data usage per subscriber increased from **2.34 GB** to **8.12 GB**. This represents an increase of approximately **247%**, meaning the latest average is roughly 3.5 times the starting level.

This finding strengthens the conclusion that the growth in data traffic was not simply the result of having more subscribers. Subscribers were, on average, consuming considerably more data.

6. Monthly and Year-over-Year Growth

Monthly growth compares each month with the immediately preceding month, while year-over-year growth compares a month with the same month one year earlier. Consequently, the two measures are expected to show different patterns.

For year-over-year data usage growth, the minimum observed value was **28.25% in April 2025**, while the latest and highest reported value was **44.15% in May 2026**. The consistently positive YoY values indicate sustained expansion in data consumption rather than a single isolated increase.

7. Network-Generation Migration

Network	Starting	Latest	Change
2G	58.36%	36.12%	–22.24 pp
3G	16.46%	5.10%	–11.36 pp
4G	25.06%	54.30%	+29.24 pp
5G	0.12%	4.49%	+4.37 pp

The combined share of 2G and 3G declined from **74.82%** to **41.22%**, while 4G and 5G increased from **25.18%** to **58.79%**. This demonstrates a pronounced migration toward newer network generations.

Important interpretation: the data supports an association between network modernization and rising data consumption, but it does not establish that the shift to 4G/5G caused the increase in data usage. The relationship should therefore be described as occurring alongside the growth in data consumption rather than as a proven causal effect.

8. Integrated Market Interpretation

Taken together, the findings describe a telecom market undergoing simultaneous contraction and intensification. The subscriber base became smaller, but the remaining market generated much more Internet traffic. Competitive strength also became increasingly concentrated in MTN and Airtel, while Globacom and T2 lost substantial subscriber share.

At the same time, the technology profile of subscribers changed significantly, with 4G and 5G gaining ground at the expense of 2G and 3G. These trends point toward a market increasingly centered on higher-capacity networks and heavier data consumption.

9. Operator-Level Data Usage: Limitation and Research Opportunity

The available Clean_Data table contains Internet Data Usage (TB) at the overall market level, not separate monthly data-usage values for MTN, Airtel, Globacom and T2. Therefore, the dashboard should not claim that one operator consumed more data than another.

This is an important limitation because an operator with fewer subscribers could theoretically generate greater data traffic per subscriber. Operator annual reports may provide data-usage-per-customer or related metrics, but such figures must be checked for comparable definitions, periods and units before being combined with the NCC dataset.

This therefore represents a strong opportunity for further research: comparing operator-level data intensity could reveal whether subscriber market share accurately reflects data-usage strength.

10. Final Conclusion

Overall, the project shows that Nigeria's telecommunications market changed substantially between January 2023 and May 2026. Subscriber numbers fell by about 16%, but Internet data usage increased by roughly 190%, while average monthly data usage per subscriber rose from 2.34 GB to 8.12 GB.

The competitive landscape shifted toward MTN and Airtel, and the network profile moved strongly from 2G/3G toward 4G/5G. The most important conclusion is therefore that **subscriber numbers alone do not fully describe the evolution of the telecom market**; data intensity, market concentration and network-generation adoption provide important additional perspectives.